coursera | MoMA

Seeing Through Photographs

Today's goal • 3/3 items

Module 1
Introduction to Seeing Through Photographs

Module 2
One Subject, Many Perspectives

Module 3
Documents and the Documentary

Module 4
One and Another

Part I: Introduction
- Introduction to Module 4 — Reading • 2 min
- Sarah Meister on Photography and Multiplicity — Video • 2 min

Part II: Albums and Books
- Artwork Spotlight: Frances Benjamin Johnston's The Hampton Album, 1899–1900 — Reading • 2 min
- Hear More: Sarah Meister on Frances Benjamin Johnston. The Hampton Album. 1899–1900 — Video • 1 min
- Practical Scenario — Real-world application • 5 min
- Photo Books — Reading • 8 min

Part III: Bodies of Work
- Photo Series — Reading • 13 min
- Hear More: Nicholas Nixon on The Brown Sisters, 1975–2022 — Video • 1 min
- Practical Scenario — Real-world application • 5 min
- Hear More: Sohrab Hura on Snow, 2015–ongoing — Video • 5 min

Part IV: One from Many
- One from Many — Reading • 8 min
- Hear More: Irina Rozovsky on Miracle Center, 2019–ongoing — Video • 5 min

Part V: Review and Respond
- Practice Memory Check — Practice Assignment • Grade: 80%
- Optional Discussion Prompts and Creative Challenges — Reading • 10 min
- Optional Readings and Resources — Reading • 10 min
- Optional Mid-Course Survey — Reading • 5 min

Module 5
Constructing Narratives, Challenging Histories

Part I: Introduction
- Introduction to Module 5 — Reading • 2 min
- Artwork Spotlight: Hank Willis Thomas's UNBRANDED series — Reading • 2 min
- Hank Willis Thomas on the Role of Advertising Images — Video • 3 min

Part II: Re-envisioning History
- Constructing History — Reading • 4 min
- Practical Scenario — Real-world application • 5 min
- Challenging History — Reading • 6 min
- Hear More: Carrie Mae Weems on From Here I Saw What Happened and I Cried, 1995–96 — Video • 2 min
- Hear More: Walid Raad of The Atlas Group on My neck is thinner than a hair: Engines, 1996–2001 — Video • 1 min
- Practical Scenario — Real-world application • 5 min
- Hear More: Harrell Fletcher on The American War, 2005 — Video • 4 min

Part III: Envisioning Selves and Stereotypes
- Constructing Personal Narratives — Reading • 10 min
- Hear More: Iñaki Bonillas on Constructing Identities — Video • 5 min
- Hear More: Eva Respini on Cindy Sherman. Untitled Film Stills. 1977–80 — Video • 1 min
- Hear More: David Alekhuogie on To Live and Die in LA, 2019 — Video • 4 min

Part IV: Review and Respond
- Practice Memory Check — Practice Assignment • 30 min
- Optional Discussion Prompts and Creative Challenges — Reading • 10 min
- Optional Readings and Resources — Reading • 10 min

Module 6
Pictures of People

Module 7
Ocean of Images

Constructing History

0:04 / 3:45 1x

Felice Beato



Felice Beato. *Interior of Pehtang Fort Showing Probyn's Horses*. 1860. Albumen silver prints, 9 7/16 × 23 1/4" (24 × 59.2 cm). The Museum of Modern Art, New York. Acquired through the generosity of Shirley C. Burden and the Estate of Vera Louise Fraser

Not long after the invention of the medium, photographers began to document wars. Felice Beato was among the first to do this when he traveled to China to document the second Opium War (1856–60). Because lengthy exposure times did not allow him to capture action, Beato photographed the aftermath and the sites of the battle of Britain and France against China. Several images suggest that he may have positioned his subjects and some of the objects in the scenes to craft a more balanced composition—and he sometimes stitched together as many as eight photographs to create broad panoramic views. Beato sequenced and captioned these photographs and bound them into an album, creating a narrative of the conflict slanted toward a European audience—a perspective that has been critically challenged due to new scholarship on colonial photography and the ways the medium was used as a tool of Western imperialism.

Unknown Photographer



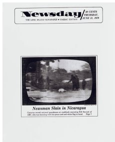
Unknown Photographer. *The Great War*. 1918–19. Gelatin silver prints (stereograph), Overall 3 9/16 x 7 3/8" (9 x 18.8 cm). The Museum of Modern Art, New York. Purchase

This stereograph of a uniformed soldier beside his airplane was made to be viewed through a stereoscope which, due to how our binocular vision works, makes the pair of left- and right-eye- view images appear three-dimensional. Stereographs were invented around the same time as photography, and they were quickly made available at affordable prices. They were a huge commercial success, and the variety of subject matters they covered allowed people to learn about and place themselves at the scene of distant locales and significant events. Made to engage and educate viewers, they were often sold as thematic collections, in this case, part of a set called "The Great War" produced by the British stereograph company Realistic Travels.

Sarah Charlesworth



Sarah Charlesworth. *Movie-Television-News-History, June 21, 1979*. 1979. Twenty-seven chromogenic color prints, printed 2010, each approx. 22 × 14" (55.9 × 35.6 cm). The Museum of Modern Art, New York. The Contemporary Arts Council of The Museum of Modern Art and Committee on Photography Fund. © 2020 Estate of Sarah Charlesworth



Detail from Sarah Charlesworth. *Movie-Television-News-History, June 21, 1979*. 1979.

Sarah Charlesworth investigated the ways in which images circulate through news channels and how our understanding of those images is shaped by that context. To make *Movie-Television-News-History, June 21, 1979*, she collected and photographed the front pages of twenty-seven newspapers, all published on the same day. Each newspaper ran the story of Bill Stewart, an ABC News correspondent killed on camera while covering the Nicaraguan Revolution, accompanied by one or more photographic stills of this televised scene. By removing content from the front pages so that only the images, captions, and headlines remain, Charlesworth draws attention to the varying treatment of the event. The placement of the story on the page—above or below the fold—and size of the images gives a sense of the story's newsworthiness according to each newspaper's editors.

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